



FOR MORE
STORIES

TIMING OF SYED MUSHTAQ ALI TROPHY A DISSERVICE TO THE PLAYERS

With the 2025 IPL auction completed just two days into SMAT, grand performances in this tournament **went without reward.**



Effort in vain:

MP captain Rajat Patidar's unbeaten 40-ball 81 couldn't stop Mumbai's charge towards the title.

K. MURALI KUMAR



Ashwin Achal

achal.ashwin@thehindu.co.in

The Mumbai line-up for the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (SMAT) wore an intimidating look. No less than six players had represented India, and new, hungry match-winners stood tall when called into action.

And who said you cannot teach an old dog new tricks? At 36, Mumbai opener Ajinkya Rahane was in prime form. With 469 runs at a strike rate of 164.56, Rahane emerged as the highest run-scorer of the tournament. His breathtaking attacking style in the PowerPlay played a major part in Mumbai claiming its second SMAT title.

Rahane's prime position was challenged by Madhya Pradesh's Rajat Patidar. Patidar looked a cut above the rest, as he flourished on a spongy M. Chinnaswamy Stadium pitch while his teammates struggled. Patidar's big-match temperament was on display in the final against Mumbai, when he struck an unbeaten 81 to single-handedly keep MP in contention.

Patidar, who was retained by Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB), took in the applause of the crowd. His grand showing in this tournament no doubt augurs well for RCB in IPL 2025.

With Prithvi Shaw, captain Shreyas Iyer, Rahane, and Suryakumar Yadav in the top order, Mumbai had star power aplenty. But it was the unheralded Suryansh